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Larry Ridley

Bassist Larry Ridley was born in Indianapolis, Indiana on September 3, 1937. He played with Freddie Hubbard and Wes Montgomery as a teenager and went on to perform and record with many prominent jazz artists. Larry recently retired as professor from Rutgers University and is currently the head of the IAJE African American Jazz Caucus.

Larry was interviewed in Toronto, Canada on January 10, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Toronto at the IAJE convention. I'm extremely pleased to have Larry Ridley with me today.

LR: Thank you, Monk, my pleasure.

MR: You have had a marvelous career in different parts of the music. And I'm wondering if when you were a boy or a young man at what point did you set your career path? Is it possible — was it that definite of a time?

LR: Well I think that there are little pivot points that sort of set the tone for what my destiny — if I can use that word — was to be. I think my spiritual values came from the time that I was an altar boy in the African Methodist Episcopal Church. My brother and I, my brother that's next to me, we were both at an early age, seven years old or something like that. And my mother was originally a Baptist so I came up through that whole African-American tradition of Baptist church and then the African-American Episcopal Church. So certain spiritual values, and then my family, I came from a very large family. My mother came from a family of 13 kids. So the get-togethers at my grandparents' home was always like a mini-United Nations. And I became very early aware of the differences in personalities and people like this. So a combination of those kind of spiritual aspects and also recognizing the differences that exist among people. And as I've grown older you know you realize all of these things transcend ethnicity or the limitations of ethnicity, you realize that human beings are human beings. And you begin to just look and see what are those things and you do a quick study on being able to have insight into understanding that and how to not be unnerved by certain types of situations. I started playing music when I was three years old, playing the violin. In fact I had like a little tiny violin it was about that size. And unfortunately I had some pictures, and I like to think that they were cute, everybody says that they were cute, but I think a lot of them were lost in memorabilia that my parents had in our home in Indianapolis and so it's up here. So God knows. But the music thing, and then I had an uncle, Ben Holliman, who was a

gentleman who befriended Hoagy Carmichael. In fact my Uncle Ben always told me that the major part of the song "Stardust" was his.

MR: Oh my.

LR: A lot of people are not aware of this. And Hoagy was very close to my uncle for all of his life.

MR: And your uncle was a musician?

LR: Yes. He was an entertainer and he was a good friend of Eubie Blake. In fact Eubie Blake told me stories about how they met. Eubie was traveling through Indianapolis, Indiana and Eubie was kind of down on his finances. So he went to the local pool hall and he was an excellent pool shark. And he kind of played down his ability and he told these guys, "Yeah well I'd like to shoot a few rounds" and they set up the limits for whatever the wager would be. And so he proceeded to just kind of take it easy and then after a while he immediately started running the table on them. And these guys were ready to jump up and guys were pulling out their knives and everything, talking about, "We're going to cut this guy." And my uncle knew all these guys and being that Eubie was a stranger just passing through, you know they didn't know who this guy was and they say oh this guy comes in and is going to set us up and take all our money. And so my uncle saved him from these guys. Which I thought was a great story.

MR: It is a great story.

LR: And Eubie acknowledged it.

MR: He never would have reached a hundred.

LR: My uncle didn't tell me that, Eubie told me that, which is great. So playing music and then as I was a kid I was a part of a music club and all the young musicians around town like Freddie Hubbard, Virgil Jones, Mel Ryan and David Hardiman, on and on, we all came up playing jazz. And the Montgomery brothers, Wes, Buddy and Monk were there. And Monk befriended me, and it's very interesting how as a young teenager — well first, how I came to play the bass was I went to a Jazz at the Philharmonic concert. And Ray Brown, Herb Ellis and Oscar Peterson and Ella Fitzgerald did a set that just totally knocked my socks off. And I said — because I'd been playing the violin — but I said that is what I want to do.

MR: This was in Indianapolis?

LR: In Indianapolis, yes.

MR: At about what year would it have been?

LR: Oh God I can't remember. I was about twelve or thirteen years old so I can't do the math.

MR: So maybe '47?

LR: Somewhere around in there, yeah. Somewhere around in there. And I got a bass, and there was a friend of mine at the high school who had a bass, had one of those old tin

basses that they had, because they confiscated most of the wood and the plywood that the King Company were using to make basses. So they made these tin basses.

MR: I've seen one of those.

LR: Black tin bass. And this guy came from a fairly well-to-do family and his parents just gave him everything. And he just had this bass. So I talked him into letting me borrow it for a while. And I taught myself how to play the bass.

MR: Was jazz, before this seeing Ray Brown, was jazz part of your household?

LR: Oh yes. My parents were into Duke Ellington, Count Basie. My mother's youngest brother was into the more current stuff like with the bebop and stuff like that. And all these musicians around town, you know, like were all very supportive. There are so many names I hesitate to name a lot of names, but I mentioned the main ones like the Montgomery brothers and David Baker. David Baker was there and he is a few years older than me but he's like my big brother and he's always looked out for me. In fact when I went to Yale University we were roommates. And my mother always told him, said, "David now you make sure that he studies." David and I roomed and we had bunk beds. And David used to always pull me out of the bed and I have to say that David Baker is one of the — I'm fortunate to have a brother like him. Even though we're not blood brothers we are brothers. Because he has taken care of me since I was a young guy and he's always been there for me and he's always encouraged me, and he's a phenomenal person. You know when they start talking about who's the dean of jazz education, it's David Baker. Because he was one of the first — he and Jerry Coker were one of the first guys, and then John Mehegen came along with his books trying to define and articulate in a codified way, improvisation. Because most of what we learned, I mean we used to transcribe guys' solos and try to figure out how they were doing this over the chords and this, that and the other. But David was one of the first to start putting this in a form that was accessible to teach how to play jazz and Jerry too. Jerry is a very dear friend too. And then Jamie Aebersold came in as a freshman at Indiana University when I was there, and David was there, and that's how he got his start. Because he was a protege of David Baker also.

MR: Can you imagine that any of them could envision where that led? You know this gathering here is astounding to me.

LR: Well that's what's so beautiful about it. We were dealing with it as a labor of love not particularly knowing which way it was going to go. And I was very fortunate to be involved early on, as David refers to one of the Renaissance men of trying to get jazz in. When I went to Indiana University, 1955, I saw how the European art form and classical players were moving in and out doing their gigs and coming back to the university to teach. And I said if the seed was planted then, I said someday I'm going to try to do what

I can do to make sure that jazz becomes recognized. Because I always recognized that in order for jazz to be truly recognized as a legitimate art form that there is going to have to be an acceptance by the Academy in quotes.

MR: At that time, '55, was there resistance in that Academy?

LR: Oh most definitely. Most definitely. And it's only really started to lighten up to a certain extent over the past few years. But I mean the old man that started Berklee College of Music, he was one of the first people that started something in the Boston area — Mr. Berk. And you see the behemoth that they've become. And I sometimes lament the fact that some of the direction I know that he wanted things to go had sort of been absorbed into a much broader range now so that it's beyond Berklee's — their modus operandi is much broader than just jazz. They are reflecting on being contemporary.

MR: Contemporary music, yeah. Which is cool.

LR: But jazz, recognizing its roots in Africa and coming through the African-American experiences and then incorporating all the other elements that it has done, you know I think that it's important that that be emphasized in all jazz degree curriculums. And also it should be taught on the elementary, secondary and the higher education levels. Because Mary Lou Williams came up with this thing about the living tree of jazz. And if we are going to recognize this art form as a living tree you have to recognize the roots. And if you don't continue to fertilize and nurture those roots in order for it to keep growing new branches and new leaves with the cyclical forces of nature, which is what life is all about, it dies. And it loses a certain fundamental part of what it's about. And it's important. I mean what they teach, the European style of music, I mean they go back to the Gregorian chant and bring it through. So when you study it that's what you know. There's a continuum. And the same way with jazz. It's not saying that we don't have music that's in a certain stage. That's one of the things I'm trying to emphasize with the hip hoppers and also the people who are doing the quote unquote smooth jazz, that they have to understand the continuum of how this music evolved. And when they talk about Africa they have to recognize that it's not just the simplistic definition of jazz as being African rhythms with European melody and harmony. There was melody and harmony in African music. And that's what Duke Ellington used to always talk about. Even though he reflected and he was wide open to the music of Ravel, Debussy, Satie, you name it, all the great European art music composers, it was how it was utilized and how that was synthesized into what was essentially African derived music.

MR: Would it be safe to say that the melodic part of the African music that filtered into jazz was more of a vocal nature, the way they sang?

LR: Well of course. I mean see the thing is that those vocal things are also a part of the instrumental techniques that were translated. Because it's a sound in your ear. That's why

a lot of jazz musicians in terms of the academic community would always say oh those jazz musicians play out of tune. Because they don't recognize it's coming from a different source. And it's not going to have that kind of thing because it's not that type of music in its purest form. So you can't use that as a barometer to negate or whatever. It's all music, but all musics have their particular parameters that codify what that music is. So in understanding — and there's also the argument in the African-American community about this because a lot of them would like try to put jazz down and say oh that's the Devil's music as opposed to the spirituals which led to the Gospels. And it's all a matter — those same musical techniques are utilized. When you hear Aretha Franklin sing "Amazing Grace," and when she sings the blues she's still using the same technique. So it's a question of the sacred text versus the secular text. And that's the only difference. Thomas E. Dorsey, who is considered the father of Gospel music, was a jazz piano player. He played jazz. And then he found a niche of moving over into that particular arena. And the Gospels, people tend to forget that the Gospels grew out of the spirituals. And a lot of those things came out of the old African chants and things like that. So there's that tie. You can't chop it off and say that it started now. No, no. We all are the sum of many parts — S-U-M — and we are also a part of a tradition and a legacy. But there are a lot of people who are not being taught that and the insight into understanding how important it is if you truly want to be a person of substance you must go back and you must — I used to tell my students all the time at Rutgers — I was there for 28 years — and I told them I said look just don't take everything I say as being total Gospel. I want you to cross reference what I am telling you. Because that's what I've done in arriving at the conclusions that I have. And it's important for you so that you are truly ingrained with feeling that you are confident in taking the stance in the posture you have. You're entitled to your own ideas and your feelings about a lot of things. But make sure that your points of view are responsible and well thought out and well researched. And that way you don't find yourself caught in the cross about all these things. If somebody says, "Well how do you know that?" Well going back you can begin to tie it in. So you're just not making wild assumptions. Case in point there's a thing in the new *Jazz Times* where Gary Giddins is talking about Kenny G. And I must check with Gary to find out if this is really true but supposedly in an interview with Ted Pankin, who is with WKCR FM in New York, the Columbia University jazz radio station, they feature a lot of jazz because Phil Schaap is there. Kenny G supposedly attributes the fact that Charlie Parker got his nickname Bird because he had something happen with his reeds and it sounded like he was chirping. Now I hope — I didn't mean to mess up my interview, it was Monk talking about Kenny G. But I mean I'm just using that as an example as a case in point of what I'm talking about, how a person in his position who has gained his own personal

mission and I have no problem with him, that's what he does, it's music that you can talk over, have in the background. It's not like when I hear Charlie Parker and I stop and say oh wow, check that out what he did going through that chord change. You know Kenny's found his niche and hey, God bless him. He's doing his thing. But it's just very interesting when people in situations like this take it upon themselves to make these wild assumptions and to misinform people. And we need to do away with that kind of stuff. And if he doesn't know the answer to a certain kind of thing he doesn't have to fabricate anything. And that's what a lot of people do. It's the problem with a lot of writers and a lot of critics. They don't do their homework, they don't check with musicians, they don't understand the musician's point of view. They don't take the time to understand. They don't study the history of the music because it's still just their opinion. But many of them are in certain positions where they can make or break, just like the theater critics do with plays that are on Broadway or other things. They make or break peoples' careers with what they say. But I think that all of these people who put themselves in that position and sort of posture themselves as being authorities or experts need to make sure that they have really, really done their homework. Otherwise I don't want to talk to them. I really don't. And the whole thing about jazz polls. I had a long conversation with Leonard Feather. Leonard Feather told me that the jazz polls started because as a young man coming here to the United States he was totally enamored with jazz. And he expected when he came to the states that he was going to find these jazz musicians wearing nothing but the finest clothes, riding around in limousines and having these fantastic women on their arm and living in mansions and blah, blah, blah. He had this whole fantasy going. When he gets here he finds out a lot of these musicians were just struggling and starving. So he went to the magazines and started pitching them — why aren't you talking about these great musicians that you have here? And they told him point blank he said, we are only interested in selling magazines. If you can come up with an idea that will help us to sell magazines we'll be glad to incorporate that. So that's when he came up with the *Esquire* and *Metronome* and the *Down Beat* polls and that's how that became a factor in the jazz community. And it's kind of gotten out of hand because it's become very political, I mean a lot of people don't know but the ballot boxes are stuffed. It's almost like the Florida election.

MR: Oh you're kidding.

LR: Where we finally, or for the first time, had a president elected by the Supreme Court as opposed to the President appointing the Supreme Court. But that's another story, right Monk? But some of the same elements. Like people stuffing the ballot box, and industry buying time and promoting their artists and this, that and the other, so it becomes incumbent upon them — the Grammys — we know that that's all political.

MR: Wow. Well those are great statements. And I'm curious as to whether music played a big role in your church?

LR; Oh yes.

MR: And did you get involved in that music in your church as a young boy?

LR: Couldn't help it. It was part of the environment and you didn't even think of it as some sort of separate component. It was just the fabric of life. As I look back over it as we see the way things are being broken down, oh yes, Milt Jackson came up in the church and he did this and that's the reason why he's playing the vibes the way he plays the vibes. Well when he was coming up he wasn't thinking about that as something separate and apart from — it's just a part of the everyday lifestyle. You know you're hearing it all the time. I'm hearing this music. So it was just natural. I'm around all this spiritualism, the various preachers and stuff like that, they're a part of your community, you know them. You are participating in church activities. It's just a way of life. And my parents, I'm very blessed that I have such great parents who gave me the opportunity and exposed me. We didn't have a lot of money but we weren't wanting for anything in terms of the true, spiritual food. And that's what counts. And my mother and my grandfather always taught me — because I came up under the heavy racism and segregation and went to segregated schools, all that whole thing. And I was a part of a token group that was allowed to integrate the high school that I went to. And it was based upon what kind of I.Q. that I seemed to exhibit to them and they thought well we'll let the colored kid in.

MR: No kidding. So this would have been —

LR: 1951. In Indianapolis, Indiana.

MR: In Indianapolis.

LR: Where the Ku Klux Klan was thriving. Believe me.

MR: Did this group of students that you were included in, what was your reception like with your fellow white students?

LR: You know young people are a lot more flexible than older people think sometimes. And of course there were some people that were aloof and strange and may have come from homes that taught them to have somewhat slanted maybe potentially racist viewpoints. But for the most part we were just kids. We just had a ball. The guy I was telling you about that I got this bass from, this tin bass, he was a white kid. We were buddies. We didn't think about it. His name was Mike Phillips. Mike and I were just — I mean we were just pals. We didn't think about the fact that I'm African-American or Negro or whatever the terminology was during that particular time. Colored or anything like that. I was just a pal. We had similar things that we enjoyed and it brought us together. I mean God is good. And I don't think things happen by accident. And you learn these kind of things and it's about human values. Yes there are differences and we have different

cultural things that are different. But we can coexist. I can appreciate you. I mean I don't look at you and say oh yeah Monk is a white guy. You are just a friend. You're just a guy that I like and we have — there's a chemistry between us, and the vibes between us, there's nothing hostile about what we are feeling. I don't have any predetermined opinions about who and what you are. I come together to dialogue with you. See people spend too much time talking at or to. They don't dialogue with. It's not about monologue. It's about win-win situations. I'm not going to get a hundred percent of what I want and you're not either. But we learn how — I mean thinking people — truly thinking spiritual people think along the lines, in my opinion, of learning how do we coexist? How do we win-win? And how do we — if I have a difference of opinion about a certain thing, let's engage in discussion. Let me share with you why I feel the way I feel and let me hear why you feel the way you feel. And let's leave it so that we're both open to the fact that it's not carved in stone in terms of what our opinions or our feelings are at that given moment. Because education is an ongoing process. And once you stop learning, you're dead. Because studies have been conducted where they say the percentage of our brain power that we utilize, and the averages are very small when you consider it in the ratio of zero to a hundred percent. It's over here somewhere, more towards the zero side. And then you get people who are very brilliant and they're stretching that thing saying hey wait a minute, I want more of this. Because we're all just passing through and we're trying to — because I believe that this is not the final destination. I really believe that. A friend of mine — just a little quick comical anecdote, because I like to use a levity on occasion, but a friend of mine told me he says the reason why he believes in reincarnation is because he says you look at Colonel Sanders. He keeps killing those chickens and they keep coming back. I know it's corny. I'm from Indiana, what can I say, Monk?

MR: It's okay. You're right, there couldn't be an endless supply of those chickens. When you got close to graduation in high school, what kind of career, what were your prospects? What were you thinking of?

LR: Well I was fortunate in that Freddie Hubbard and James Spaulding and a lot of us, we had our own little bands and we were playing jazz. In fact we had a hot little band. My uncle was friendly with some gentlemen who owned a club in Indianapolis. And we had a gig, we worked six nights a week with two matinees, and we were just teenagers. We were playing all the Art Blakey Jazz Messenger, Clifford Brown, Max Roach charts and everything. And we had a piano player by the name of Al Plank, a white guy who lives in San Francisco now, been living there for several years, and he was — he was not out first pianist, we had another guy Walt Miller who was the original pianist — but then Al Plank came in. And Al had the ability to help write a lot of arrangements and then Freddie and we all contributed some stuff to the repertoire. But we gained a reputation

throughout the midwest in terms of our little group. And I had my first road gig when I was sixteen, with Conte Candoli.

MR: Was this the Jazz Contemporaries?

LR: The Jazz Contemporaries, yeah. That was the group.

MR: With Conte Candoli?

LR: No Conte Candoli, that was something —

MR: I'm sorry, I missed what you said.

LR: The group with Freddie Hubbard and Jimmy Spaulding and first Walt Miller then Al Plank and Paul Parker was the drummer. And then we used to play with Wes. The first time I saw Monk Montgomery and I approached him about taking lessons from him he told me, "Well come over to the house, kid." I went over to the house and there is Wes sitting up there with the guitar and his brother Buddy at the piano. A saxophone player by the name of Pookie Johnson and the drummer Sonny Johnson. They called themselves the Montgomery-Johnson Quintet and they had a steady gig working in a place called the Turf Club. So Monk says, "Go over and pick up the bass." I said, "What?" "Go over and pick up the bass." So I went over and picked up the bass and they struck up a tune. And I'm saying wait a minute, what's happening here. He said, "Look kid, I'm going out to the west coast because I'm beginning, starting a group called The Master Sounds, and I'm going to have to go out there to set up some business and I'm going to be gone for two weeks and I want you to fill in for me." "Yes sir, Mister Montgomery." And here I was man, that was his way of teaching me. He never really gave me a lesson other than me absorbing and listening and watching and listening to him perform. But as far as saying okay you do this and you do that, I taught myself that in the very beginning. And of course I knew from playing the violin you know, so I taught myself the bass clef and all that. And then I had great teachers on the violin. I had a young lady who was with the Indianapolis Symphony Orchestra who was my teacher. There was a woman by the name of Ruth MacArthur who had a conservatory there. She was a young African-American woman who set up a conservatory, and Slide Hampton and his whole family and all of us used to go there. And she had a relationship with the Indianapolis Symphony Orchestra where she got some of the players to teach us, in the African-American community. And they would come in and give us lessons. And so we had excellent training. And then there was some gentlemen there who were excellent mentors who taught, Mr. Russell Brown, Mr. James Compton and Laverne Newsom who taught at the high school and also in the elementary schools, Mr. Lawrence Leggett who taught me in the third grade when I was in my little elementary school orchestra. And so we had excellent instruction. And the thing was learning about it, and what I learned from Wes, it was so important, that I tried to reflect to my students how important, part of playing jazz and playing music period is

having good ears. You know because when you're up there improvising you're not thinking about oh I'm going from a D minor seventh with a flat five over here to a G seven with a raised nine. You're not thinking about all that. You've got to sit at the piano and you've got to get that sound, or the guitar, and get those sounds in your ear and know how to respond to that improvisationally through hearing lyrical lines. And that's one of the things I'm concerned about that is happening with jazz education. Too many of these kids are coming through and they sound like computers because they're learning how to play licks and patterns but they're not learning how get their own personal sound. And that's what jazz is all about, finding your own identity. I don't try to play the bass like Ray Brown or Paul Chambers or Richard Davis or any — Charlie Mingus. You know? I have learned how to be Larry Ridley. Because — as the Bible says, to thine own self be true. Of course I've learned from them and there are certain things that I have picked up from them but I don't try to just say oh, that's not the way Ray played it so I've got to go back and try that again. It's not about that.

MR: How can you foster that ability to invent melodies and what happened to you with this — being thrown in that situation? How can we do that now?

LR: They've got to learn tunes. The more songs that you know that have melodic content — the brain is like a computer. You have to — if you put garbage in you're going to get garbage out. So you have to put something up there. And one of the things that I always stress to my students when they're in the workshops and things I do, how many melodies do you know? I've done artists-in-residencies in different places. I will never forget one time I was at the University of Utah. I asked the young people what do they want to play. They says let's play "Giant Steps." I said, "Excuse me?" Okay. Blues in B flat. They said, "But we said we want to play 'Giant Steps.'" I said, "No, you have to show me that you can play the Blues in B flat, or any key for that matter, before you can talk about 'Giant Steps,'" I said, "because I came up around John Coltrane. John Coltrane, see you all come in at these different stages of hearing people. And see Coltrane is so beautiful because his career is documented on recordings. You can hear the growth. See all that stuff that he was playing at the end, he could still go back and walk the bar, which is the basic stuff in the community." I remember a woman coming up to Sonny Stitt, he came through Indianapolis playing at this club and he was up there just taking it easy because he thought well I'm in Indianapolis I'll just kind of take it easy. This woman came up to him and she says, "Sonny Stitt, let me tell you something. I spent my last five dollars to come in here to hear you play because I like your music." She said, "But you better stop bullshitting on that stage or I'm going to take one of these chairs and go upside your head." So he said, "Oh, excuse me, madam" and commenced to bear down and start playing. And it's that kind of thing. You know like but they have to know melodies. They

have to learn tunes. They're learning too many things like exercises that take you through the two-five-one progression. Or I'm going to play the Dorian or the Lydiot or Idiot scale.

MR: I like the Lydiot.

LR: Or the demented scale. And they have to understand that you're composing music. And you have to relate to your audience. Nobody wants to come and hear you practice. I don't want to come and hear you sit up and play exercises. I mean do that in your house or in your practice room or something like that. You have to learn how to compose music. That's the beauty of jazz. You're called upon to be an instantaneous composer. You have to learn how to build your solos. I hear these kids, they're just playing ad infinitum. Well let me show you everything I've practiced today. No. That's not music. When you listen to Bach, Beethoven, any of those European art music masters it's just like writing — that's why I always compare it to English composition even. You know you have to have an introduction, you introduce your theme, your thesis, you develop it, you recapitulate, you do a summarization and then you lock up and bow as Kenny Dorham used to say. Kenny used to say, "Get two choruses of your best shit together baby, and lock up and bow out." And Charlie Parker used to say, "It's always best to leave people wanting more." And Milt Jackson used to tell me, "Once you get past the third chorus you're practicing."

MR: That's so interesting because also, those guys had to operate in a time when the length on a record was very limited.

LR: That's right.

MR: They couldn't go on and on and on.

LR: Well Max Roach was telling me that when the 78s were, that sometimes you would only get four bars. And even in playing in the bands. And that's what spawned a lot of the jam sessions because guys were frustrated because they wanted to improvise and stretch out more. But sometimes in a band you might have one tune that was your feature for that night, and if you acted up with the band leader you might not even get to play it that night. So then you'd leave there a nervous wreck. "I didn't get a chance to really do my thing." You know. And the thing is when you go back and listen to those records by the Freddie Websters and Lester Youngs, they didn't play a whole lot of choruses. And Charlie Parker used to always say that. Leave them wanting some. Roy Haynes told me when he was first playing, was basically auditioning for the gig with Lester Young, he was playing and he was just slam-banging and everything and he was going through his stuff. He said Prez just kind of, he says, "No bombs, Prez, just tinti-boom, tinti-boom, and then waltz back out again and started playing some more." And then after Roy settled down and started swinging behind him and just listening to him and playing to support

him then Prez kind of waltzed back again and said, "If you've got eyes, Prez, the slave is yours." And that's how he got hired with Lester Young.

MR: Oh that's great.

LR: Lester Young was beautiful. And to see Lester Young, Harry Edison and Vic Dickinson get together and Papa Jo Jones, those guys could talk man, and you wouldn't know what the hell they were talking about. They had their own esoteric language. They could talk to each other and you wouldn't know a word of what they're talking about. And that's why I feel so blessed that I had the opportunity to come up playing with all those guys. I mean and Joe Venuti and oh man, well if people go to the web site, I've got all the names, and I've been blessed.

MR: You've been through the list, it's great.

LR: And I have just tried to absorb. And I always tell my students too, and even other people, you know like don't get so cocky with such an attitude. The music is greater than all of us. Just because you think you know a little more than the average — I would say Duke Ellington, as great as he was, he could talk to just a person on the street, a homeless person, and make them feel like they were millionaires or heads of state, and he could go and talk to royalty and the same thing. And he always, he was fantastic. That was a hell of an experience for me to be around him. He was just — oh I don't know what to say.

MR: Well it's partly a spiritual thing, don't you think?

LR: Coltrane. John Coltrane was one of the most humble people that you ever wanted to — and one of the most focused people. Eric Dolphy. Eric Dolphy, we lived, a bunch of us lived in the same house. See how I got to know Coltrane personally, I had met him in the fifties but I had really got to know him because I lived at this house. When you see on Eric Dolphy's record "245" — 245 was the address of a brownstone that Slide Hampton owned in Brooklyn. 245 Carleton Avenue. And Charles Greenlee was married to Coltrane's cousin Mary.

MR: Cousin Mary. The tune.

LR: Yes. So he lived in the house, and she's like my sister you know. And Billy Fraser, Slide Hampton, all of us, Freddie Hubbard, we all lived in that house. And there was so much music and Yusef Lateef and all kinds of people would come through the house. And Coltrane and I used to go out to Coltrane's house and hang out with him. I knew him man, I knew this guy. And he was so beautiful and so focused. Sonny Rollins man, Wynton Kelly man, all these guys man, Philly Jo Jones took me on like a little brother, taught me so much. Papa Jo Jones. And Coleman Hawkins. When I worked with Coleman Hawkins I used to just sit up for hours with him just asking him. Because I wanted to know more of the — I had an acquaintancship with Leonard Feather and we would talk and I had a great deal of respect for Leonard Feather and his role. But there

were a lot of critics and historians that I take issue with because they are not of the same mold like the Leonard Feathers or the Dan Morgensterns. They don't have the same kind of humbleness and the same kind of commitment. Some woman came up to me the other day because she was very disturbed about what Oscar Peterson said at the gala the other day. And she asked me, "What do you think about that?" I said, "He was absolutely on the money." She said, "What?" I said, "Yes, he was telling you the truth. I mean don't you respect what he had to say?" He's not a man — I worked with Oscar — Oscar's not a man that takes things lightly. And he doesn't make comments to be cavalier. When he says something check it out. Because there's pearls of wisdom. And Oscar Peterson, excuse me. I mean if you can't respect him and try to just don't get an attitude and start thinking oh well he's just bitter or this that and the other. People spend too much time trying to easily categorize or pigeon-hole people too quickly without taking the time to understand what are the conditions that has brought a human being to that particular level of whatever. Whether we're talking about the frustration factor or even the satisfaction. Life is much more complex than some people would — but everybody's looking for the quick fix. They want the instant on. And this whole thing about jazz education can't be about a Swanson T.V. dinner. You know you get a Charlie Parker Omni book and learn a few Charlie Parker solos and look at me, I'm playing instant jazz. It's not about that. That's not the way you develop what we were saying before about learning these melodies. Getting inside of hearing your own sound. Yes we are all influenced by different people but I'm tired of hearing Coltrane clones. Find your own sound. That's what's so beautiful about when you go back and listen to these guys. I mean Lester Young was Lester Young. Stan Getz is Stan Getz. Zoot Sims is Zoot Sims. Hank Mobley is Hank Mobley. Sonny Stitt is Sonny Stitt. Dizzy Gillespie is Dizzy Gillespie. Miles Davis is Miles Davis. Fats Navarro. On and on and on. We can do that on all the instruments. And what makes them special is because they are themselves. And if you're not trying to find your own identity I mean Ernest Hemingway is not trying to be William Shakespeare. Bach wasn't — you know Mozart wasn't trying to be Bach. Stravinsky was not trying to be Wagner. People in the arts, just like actors and actresses. And it's true in all professions when we look at it. So it's not something that's just only in music or even in art. Gauguin and Rembrandt. Renoir. All these people are different. They found their thing that becomes them. Frank Lloyd Wright. I.M. Pei.

MR: Have we kind of created a conflict then with jazz education is now a big business with publications and method books and all that. And this gathering here obviously is positive in some aspects for the music, but is it creating too many of the people you're talking about that just are spinning out what the book says?

LR: Well that's why I think that people like myself and I have other people who are disciples like I am in recognizing how this can be a problem. And it's true in anything. You can always find that you're churning out clones as opposed to individualists. And we have to constantly check ourselves. And the people who are teaching and some of these degree programs need to make sure that they are structuring their curricula and their degree requirements so that you do produce people of substance and that you do produce people who recognize that they are searching for their own personal identity. Because it's a lifelong quest. You know four years in an institution of higher yearning — I mean higher learning excuse me — that's just preparing — you know there are a lot of people that come out and say oh I'm doctor so-and-so, I have a Ph.D. I say well what does that Ph.D. mean? Piled higher and deeper? And in what? So don't get carried away because you've got a little Ph.D. behind your name. That doesn't mean anything. You can find a person on the street with mother or father that can wipe you out so don't get carried away. Put your ego in your back pocket and sit on it. And just recognize that you are a fellow human being and you are never in the position where you can look down your nose at anyone about anything. And once you lose your humility and we're just like — you know how roaches are? You know we're just one roach out of thousands of roaches. We are a microcosm of the macrocosm. And so people get — and I realize that everybody is searching for self identity and all these things and they're searching for — they want to be comfortable, they want to find their own niche and everybody wants it to happen immediately. But I think it's very important that as you are striving for these things that you are approaching it with the right criteria of understanding how to approach it. It's not like I'm going to grab this. It's just like the whole problem with academia with people going for tenure. They work their butts off while they're trying to get tenure and many of them the minute they get tenure, whew.

MR: Okay I can stop learning now.

LR: And that's what creates the controversy about tenure. Because you get so many people who do that. They work their butts off to get tenure and the minute they get tenure then they're sitting on their asses for the rest of their life and trying to act like well I'm professor doctor so-and-so. So what? That and a dime ain't going to get you on the subway in New York or anywhere else for that matter. So what? Like Miles said, so what? It don't mean a thing if it ain't got that swing.

MR: Man. Let me return to your own career here for a minute. The sixties were quite an amazing era for you it seems. I don't know if you can divide it into just the sixties, but you played with a long, long list. Does anybody stand out in your own mind, particular tours or recordings that you'd just like to mention?

LR: All of it really. I mean it all is — each entity is one component or one part — when I say sum of the parts that's the reason why like my first album that I produced is called "Sum" S-U-M "of the Parts." Because I recognized that I'm the sum total of all these influences, all these people, everything that I've studied, everything that I've dedicated myself to in terms of my spirituality, my learning, my friendships with people and just trying to understand what the totality of life is all about. And it's an ongoing quest. And traveling with the Newport Jazz Festival All-Stars, sitting in the lobby in Tokyo, Japan with Joe Venuti and talking about music and hanging out with this guy and hearing his ideas. I would ask him, I'd say, "Joe, where did jazz come from? Where did you hear jazz?" He'd say, "Oh it came from the black people and that's how I learned it." And when I was playing with Paul Whiteman's group I took stuff back to him. Plus Paul Whiteman's father you know was involved with teaching Lester Young.

MR: Paul Whiteman's father?

LR: Yeah. That's — and you know you have the Pettiford family? All these territories. See and that's another thing that I am very, very adamant about too is this mythology about jazz being born only in New Orleans is a myth. Absolute myth. And I did my homework with Eubie Blake and Garvin Bushell and Doc Cheatham and people like this. And they said wherever there was a significant population of people of African descent they were creating a spontaneous improvised hot music. That's why you have the Afro-Cuban improvisation. That's their way of playing, it's essentially jazz. They're improvising, right? So and if we look at the different parts of the United States they were playing music. I mean people in Chicago weren't waiting on King Oliver to get off the riverboat and say come on in here King Oliver and teach us how to play jazz. They were already playing jazz. What was James Reese Europe doing in New York? The blues wasn't just born in the Mississippi Delta. Excuse me? Hello? If you believe in that I mean you need to get AT&T long distance or something or Worldcom. No not Worldcom, that's right, they failed. Anyway you know what I mean. But all of the people that I played with during the sixties had a profound influence on me. Sonny Rollins, John Coltrane, Dizzy Gillespie, Duke Ellington. All these people that you see listed that I have made sure that I listed at my web site and that I'm continuously reminded of, making sure I include all the people. Even people that a lot of people are not even aware of or may never have heard of or may never even understand their significance. They were significant to me because I learned from them. And I learned early on how to talk with people and not at or to.

MR: Was there ever lessons learned of things not to do?

LR: Oh yes. You know a lot has been written about alcohol and drugs in the jazz community. And I really feel that it has been overblown. And I sometimes wonder whether or not it's been used early on to kind of discredit the importance of jazz as an art form. Because that

was some of the stuff that early people say oh that music was born in the brothels and houses of ill repute. And it's funny because when I first started saying I wanted to play jazz I told my father that I wanted to play jazz, because he liked that I was playing the violin, and he said, "Oh I don't particularly like the idea of you playing jazz because you'll be in those clubs where all those people are drinking and this, that and the other." I said, "Daddy, that's not why I want to play jazz. Because this is a music that I love. That may be a venue of where I have an opportunity to present myself as a musician. But that's not why I want to get involved in it. I'm not interested in the fast life per se, you know, wine, women and song." I mean I had a certain amount of that and it was fun but I never allowed myself to get carried away with all of it. I'm not any saint by any — I mean I had my times that I acted young and foolish. But thank God my mother always gave me a sense of entertaining logic 101. And to maintain a balance. My mother is still alive. She is — what is she, 88 now. And she is just as spry and spunky. She would come in here and she would get up and start dancing. She is amazing. And my uncle, her oldest brother, is still alive, he's 94 years old and lives in Chicago and still drives his car around Chicago. Now if you can drive in Chicago, even at 23, you're doing something you know what I mean? I wouldn't get on that Dan Ryan Express. But I come from a line of long livers. My dad unfortunately passed a couple of years ago. He was 90 years old. But he lived a full life and he was a good man. And the thing that was so beautiful about my father is that when we went to the funeral there were so many people. The church was packed. I didn't realize all these people loved my father. Because my father was a very humble, giving man. A very bright man who unfortunately, because of the racism and segregation did not get an opportunity to exercise his true talents. He was an excellent mechanical drawing — he had impeccable skills. He went to Butler University and studied mechanical drafting. But he couldn't get a job. He got a job in the plants during the war at Allison Motor Company, you know they make the engines for the airplanes.

MR: Allison, yeah. Okay.

LR: Guess what? A man with this kind of knowledge. He went around to the machines and was a chip collector. Putting it in — you know, cleaning up. Because they wouldn't hire him because of his color. You know that kind of craziness. I mean here's a man, who knows what he could have contributed if he had been given the opportunity. That's why I try to tell the young African-American kids now — you don't realize the dues that people paid. And this whole thing about getting out to vote? Hey, I came up through that thing. You know I was friendly with Rap Brown and Amiri Baraka and all these guys and Stokley Carmichael, all these guys. And people want to put the Panthers down, like Huey Newton and Bobby Seale and all them. Those guys — they started out, the government and other nefarious groups that painted the picture of them being the enemies of the state.

They were just being very outspoken about what they knew that the community needed to do and the kind of racist barriers that were being placed on us. And they were crying out and they wanted to see something — they didn't pick up guns just to be some kind of warring militia group. They knew that that was the only way. I mean the Ku Klux Klan was walking around with guns. Look I come up in Klan country so I don't want nobody telling me nothing about the Klan now. These weren't no Bible toting — they wanted to talk that Bible toting stuff but you talk about a contradiction. Don't pass that bullshit to me because I know. I was with my father when I was a kid and my brother and I and we were going through a lot, a used car lot in Indianapolis. And I was about six years old. And you know how little kids are, you get in the car and you're trying to act like you're driving. And I'll never forget this guy looked — to me, as a six year old, he looked like he was about seven feet tall. A white man, he came and pulled me out of the car and said, "You little curly haired Nigger" and kicked me right in the crack of my ass. I felt every bit of that man's shoe in my ass, and kicked me so hard I pissed on myself. And I'll never forget that. But I'm not bitter about it. But it just taught me something. I learned a lesson from that. And my father, and the way my father handled the situation taught me a lot about maintaining my cool. Because naturally my father came to my defense. But he didn't get into no thing where he probably would have been hauled off to jail and this, that and the other. He handled it so diplomatically. And he put the man in his place and let him know that he was totally out of order. Here's this little kid, what was he doing? He can't even reach the pedals. He can barely shift the gears. What are you talking about? You know these are the days of the clutch. I'm talking about 1941 Plymouths and stuff like that. This is before dyna-flow and all this other stuff with the automatic gearshifts and all that stuff. No way — what was I going to do with that car? And I wasn't in there trashing the car or anything like that. But I'll never forget that and it taught me something. And not just in terms of relationships between black and white people, but there's good and bad in every ethnic group. It's just like now I feel bad about the kind of rap that people who are Islamic are getting. That there's all this racial profiling that's going on. People have to be very careful about that. And I know everybody's very uptight. Look I saw, in my apartment in New York in Manhattan I looked out my window, I was up at twenty minutes of nine to answer the telephone and I looked out my window and had a straight shot of the Twin Towers right from my bedroom. It was just like a straight shot from my bedroom window I could see that. I saw that building on fire. I thought it was just a fire. And I said well maybe the sprinklers are going to put it out but I couldn't believe what was happening. And the next thing I know, bamm. And New York became — Manhattan became an armed camp with the National Guard the state and local police. It was one of the most traumatic things anybody would want to go to who

has never been in a war zone. You were literally in a war zone. I couldn't even go past a certain point, perimeter, in my neighborhood unless I could produce I.D., a driver's license that stated I lived in a certain area, they wouldn't let me go. And I needed to go out of town and I couldn't even get out of the airport because the flights were all canceled. And I needed to have a pair of pants altered, you know, some cuffs put on my pants, I couldn't even go to the tailor because the National Guard guys wouldn't let me go into the block. They said you have no business there, you don't live there so you can't go. I said but I've got to get my pants fixed man, I'm not a terrorist, I just need to get my pants fixed. The tension and everything that existed in that city, but the way people came together. New York is a beautiful place. Because in spite of the fact that people think New York and people ask me how can you live in New York oh my God. People getting mugged and this, that and the other. But New York has got the best of the best, it's got the worst of the worst, and all the different — it's yin and yang and everything in between. And to see how people came together. And people were in tears and it was just a very traumatic experience. I didn't know what had happened to my youngest brother. He worked for the Social Security department right down in that area. And I was worried about him all day and finally in the afternoon I went out to the post office and I was coming out of the post office which is right across the street from where I live. And I see this guy standing up there and he's got all this ash and stuff on him, it was my brother.

MR: Oh my Lord.

LR: And he saw me and he was just — like he was in a daze. And when he saw me he just grabbed me. He's taller than I am and he was just beating me, "Oh Larry, oh man, I'm so glad, do you know man I could have been in that building, it could have been me, we were talking to one of our colleagues who was in the building and we were telling him to get out and the guy was talking about they've told us to stay, that just sit tight, he said, and he's gone now." You know so I had to take him, I took him up to my apartment. He had walked all the way from the World Trade Center up to where I live at 14th Street and Avenue A. And I took him upstairs and we went and got a six pack of beer, because I had to settle him down. And he took a shower and I gave him a sweat outfit of mine to put on so he'd have some clean clothes. But you see all these kind of things, it's all related to the music. People might watch this and say well we got off on a tangent.

MR: That's all right.

LR: But it's a part of what we're talking about in terms of the human condition, the human existence. And all that's a part of the music. And when a person gets up to improvise they have to reflect that in their music and that's a part of who and what you are. And so this whole thing about the jazz education and how commercialized it is in certain instances,

we just have to be a watchdog to make sure that people understand that we cannot have this sort of cookie cutter instantaneous way of producing things.

MR: You know, people sometimes complain that some of the younger musicians are being elevated to the place of having their own bands and leadership and their own albums and they're only in their early twenties or something. But then you go back and say well Clifford Brown was a leader at a young age.

LR: But he was with Max Roach and was with Art Blakey.

MR: Well that's my question. What was the difference?

LR: That's one of the things that I wish would happen again. See because a lot of what I went through personally, like Clifford Brown and different ones, Horace Silver and all, any of the guys you want to name, Donald Byrd or Barry Harris. Any of us that were coming along, we played with the older musicians. It was an apprentice period that you served. Now there is so much industry involvement of record companies wanting to sign people. And then they sign a lot of young people because many of them, they don't know what's happening and they sign them to these really ridiculous contracts and there is so much — some of those contracts are some of the most ridiculous things you ever wanted to read in your life even if you don't have a law degree. The record industry is something that is — it's always been suspect, and rightfully so. Because there's been a lot of chicanery and hook and crook stuff that has gone on. And artists and entertainers — not only in jazz but across the board and even in the acting business too — it's the same thing. The arts and entertainment, the people who love it and are the people out there doing it are the ones that get misused. And I wish the apprentice period would come back some kind of way. Some of the college situations are serving like that too, and I'd like to see more of them developed along those lines whereas you get kids who come through — because the same question is going on in the NBA now. The kids coming right out of high school going into the NBA. But I think that there is something that's lost if we don't have — particularly in this music — because we're talking about something that requires a long term commitment. Because some of these people, I mean they haven't even developed. And it's only rare that you'll have this cream that rises to the top like a Clifford Brown or a Lee Morgan or you know like some of these talents that we've seen that come along in the past that suddenly really demonstrate something that you can't quite define or describe. I don't know how you describe it. You know because everybody's trying to get to it and if we can find the formula we could bottle it and we could both make a million dollars. We could be partners, right? You know 'cause that's what we work with our students, trying to get them to understand. Because I constantly ask my students, well what do you want to do? They say I want to get a BMW, I want to have a house, I want to be a member of a country club. You know they talk about all the trappings that they want,

really. And everybody is rushing to get — now they're able to make their own CDs. And I was talking with some of the people from WBGO-FM in Newark. And they were saying that every week they get flooded with CDs from people they never even heard of. And they put on some of them and they are terrible. But what can you do? People have access to make them. And I think that the albums I've made I put a lot of thought into. And this is one of the things I admired about Herbie Hancock when he started doing his thing. Herbie always had a theme and he was always centering his thing, of all the records he would put out so that they made statements. And I think that Herbie has always been a young genius about that. And he's another one, like a young guy who came along that had a lot of stuff going on. But he also gave deference to the Red Garlands, the Tommy Flanagans, the Hank Jones, the Wynton Kellys, Bill Evans, etc. Because we have to understand. And the people that want to say this guy was the greatest — there is no such thing as the greatest in jazz. There is no such animal. Coleman Hawkins is Coleman Hawkins, John Coltrane is John Coltrane. Stan Getz is Stan Getz. We have to understand that these people reached the ultimate goal that I feel that's what's happening in jazz. Finding one's signature and personal identity. And if you're not in a quest for that you are missing the boat. And if the teachers and the professors that are counseling these young people, if they're not teaching along those lines, if they're not using those method books that we're talking about that have become a part of the publishing side of jazz education and the music industry, and these people that publish these books, they've got to step off their high horse too. They haven't written the Bible of jazz improvisation. That's just one person's interpretation in an attempt to codify. The only books that I would say that kind of rank up there, the tablets that Moses brought down from Mt. Sinai, the David Bakers and the Jerry Cokers and the John Mehegan books, and a few others, I mean I mention that because these are the guys that were at the very beginning of it. And if you haven't attempt to follow in the line of where they were coming from of trying to give people the tools to find their own identity, then you're missing the boat. Because just having someone come and being a carbon copy just 'cause they can play a few licks and sound jazzy is not playing jazz. And the smooth jazz players, they've got to recognize that too. They've got to come back. I'm tired of hearing these guys sound like they're playing with a two by four on the alto and they've all got the same harsh, guttural sound. It's very saccharin. They need to listen to Johnny Hodges and hear the difference between his sound versus a Marshall Royal, versus a Charlie Parker, versus a Jackie McLean or any other alto saxophonist. Paul Desmond even. Paul had his own sound and I applaud Paul. Because Paul wasn't trying to sound like Charlie Parker. Charlie Parker liked Lee Konitz. These guys had their own thing. And that's what you should be striving for. And cut out this garbage about who is the greatest. You know they're doing it with a

lot of these young people now. They're saying, and I'm applauding and I'm very much supportive of a lot of the things that Wynton Marsalis is doing and accomplishing. He's been anointed in a special role now. And I've known him since he was a little boy because I knew his mother and father and I was at his house when he was just a little whippersnapper going around. Because I was working in New Orleans at the Royal Sonesta Hotel with the Newport All-Stars. And Ellis had myself and Lenny McBrowne, the drummer, to come over to his house and his wife cooked breakfast for us and we sat around and talked. And I've known those kids since they were little whippersnappers. Little acorns that grew into big nuts. And Wynton has grown. You know he alienated a lot of people early on because he was very outspoken and quick to be very opinionated. And I think he's learned a great deal. But that's the folly of youth sometimes. And then when you're thrown out there and given so much access to stars and stuff, it can be overwhelming. But people are so quick to want to put him down or this, that and the other. But let's just bear with the brother. And help him out. And that's why I spent time with him when we're around, I go up to his apartment and we hang. And he respects me. And I respect him. And he knows that I respect him. And he has his thoughts and his feelings about things. But I always try to engage him in dialogue. Not talking down to him because I'm older than he. But share ideas. Because it's about win-win. Life is a constant state of negotiation.

MR: Man, you have given me some great food for thought today.

LR: Well I thank you for asking me to come, and I hope this is not the last time we have an opportunity — I hope we are able to interact on many different — you know doing workshops and clinics and whatever.

MR: Absolutely. Right

LR: Whatever way, just call me and just say, "Hey, what's happening?"

MR: I know you retired very recently from —

LR: 1999, I was retired after 28 years at Rutgers. I build the undergraduate degree program there, and the master's program there in jazz. I helped shepherd that. And I was very fortunate in that I was the first and only, at that time, and I don't know if it's changing now but I had four tenured professors in jazz. And four of them African-American. The first person I brought in was Ted Dunbar. Second person Kenny Baron. Then Bill Fielder and then of course myself. And had a lot of great people who came through there teaching and sharing there, from Don Friedman and Frank Foster to, oh God if I start naming names I'm liable to leave somebody out. But Milt Jackson, and great artists in residence. I started a lot of that stuff doing the music of — and I would have thematic presentation where the ensemble would perform the music of Charlie Parker, the music of this, and I'm continuing forth with that too. And for the last ten or eleven years now I've

been jazz artist in residence at the Schomburg Center which is a part of the New York Public Library.

MR: Sure. I visited there one time when they were doing a photo opening or something.

LR: Right. And I play in jazz artists in residence there. I do three concerts a year and I'm working at doing interviews similar to what we're doing here, and also developing workshops to have a young junior scholars program that they have instituted that's being funded by New York Life, and we're working to bring young people to understand a variety of things that they can look at as far as career paths are concerned. So I'm trying to be very active and then I'm with the executive director of the African-American Jazz Caucus and I took over that in the past couple of years and spent a lot of my own personal money and a lot of my personal time in doing a lot of this stuff myself. And I brought to fruition a project that I'd been wanting to see at the IAJE conference, an all-star student jazz ensemble comprised of students from the historically black colleges and universities. And our primary mission is that we're trying to develop the programs that the HBC used because they were originators of jazz education. Because it was the Jubilee Singers and the jazz bands that were the prime money makers for these institutions early on. It was only after the NFL and the marching bands became the predominant thing, because they were the — the Gramblings and the Florida A&Ms, they were doing all the halftime events at the NFL so it became a revenue stream. So at the historical black colleges and universities, the marching band became the heavy focus in many of them. And we're working to change that emphasis so that it's not just that but that the jazz and even the blues and other spiritual and so on, and people have to understand that the Gospels grew out of the spirituals. The spirituals were first. And the inner city schools. We've got kids coming up that don't, you know the quality of education that they're getting is horrendous. The lack of substance that they are receiving is just incredible. So we've got a big job cut out for us and it's taking everybody — I mean and the African-American Jazz Caucus is not just a closed society of only African-Americans. We're looking at anybody who recognizes what our mission is about and is empathetic with what we're trying — because we're not just talking about this for the benefit of just African-Americans. We're talking about making reality about what the history has been. Because history has been so totally distorted in many cases that we need to go back. If we're talking about revisionism, which we know is going on, we need to make sure that we revise it correctly and with substance and not cliché metaphors and all this other kind of glib Johnny-come-lately nonsense that some people entertain.

MR: Well we need more people around here like yourself.

LR: God willing.

MR: And I congratulate you on your career and what you're doing now. It's fantastic.

LR: Well thank you. And thank you again for taking the time and asking me to be a part of this. And we have to — you know you have a voice in working with us too. Because you are a sincere and dedicated person. And we need your energies and we need your expertise, you know like to bring your ideas to us. Because it's about a team. Networking. And working together works. And we need serious, dedicated people. And everybody's going to get their little niche. I know everybody's got their own little personal thing and their own little parochial turfs and parochial politics, you know we've all experienced that. God knows I went through it at Rutgers.

MR I'll bet.

LR: And the professors, we called it the Rutgers Screw. Yes, you know what I'm talking about.

MR: Yes. And you're not alone.

LR: It happens at every institution. Right?

MR: Yes.

LR: But the point is keeping our eyes on the prize and recognizing that we are kindred spirits and that we seek out each other and we have mutual empathy about what it is that we're trying to do and we're not alone. Sometimes we feel like we're alone, but we're really aren't alone. We just have to expose ourselves to forums and venues where we can have the opportunity, just like we're doing right now. You didn't know much about me other than what you read on the page. Now I hope you have a little more insight into Larry Ridley the human being.

MR: Absolutely. Yeah.

LR: And that's just the tip of the iceberg.

MR: All right.

LR: Thank you my brother.

MR: Thank you.

LR: We are brothers.

MR: All right. Appreciate it.

LR: Thank you.